

HiveForce Labs

THREAT ADVISORY

 **ATTACK REPORT**

Chinese APT Espionage Turns Telecom Systems Into Covert Relay Nodes

Date of Publication

January 13, 2026

Admiralty Code

A1

TA Number

TA2026011

Summary

First Seen: 2022

Threat Actor: UAT-7290

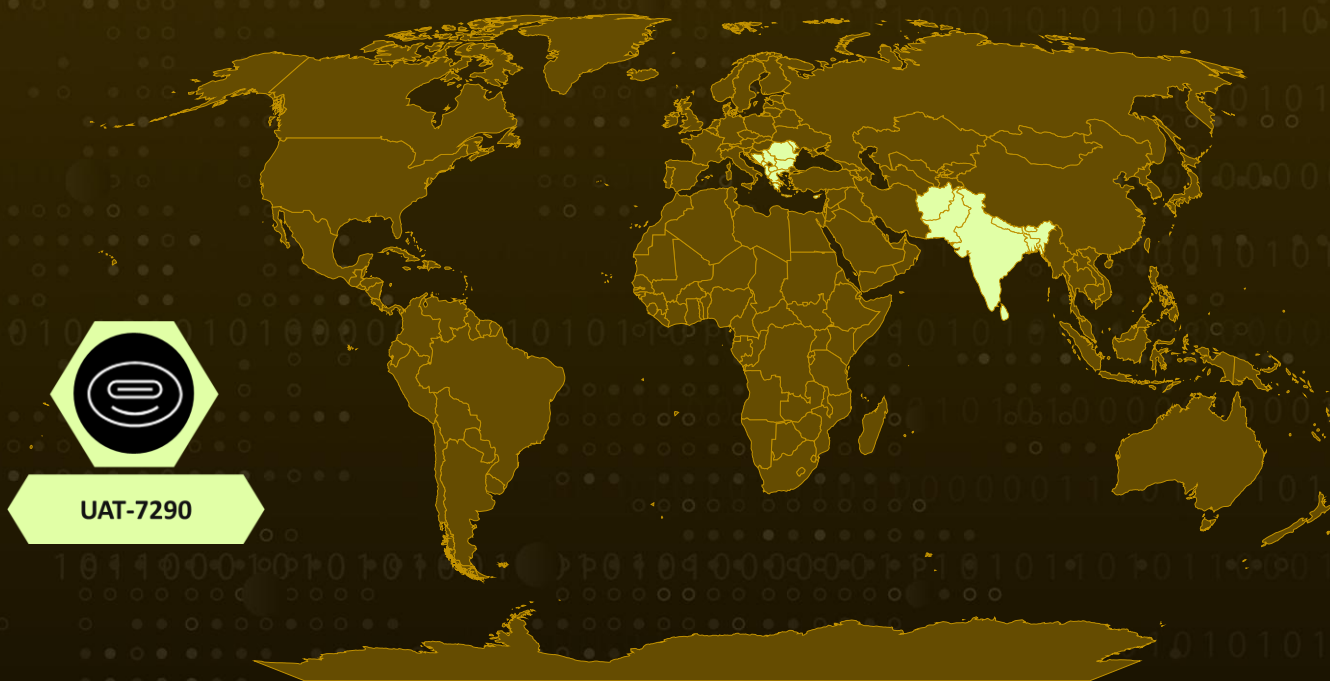
Malware: RushDrop, DriveSwitch, SilentRaid, Bulbature

Targeted Regions: South Asia, Southeastern Europe

Targeted Industries: Critical Infrastructure, Telecommunications

Attack: UAT-7290 is a China-linked advanced persistent threat that has targeted telecommunications infrastructure since at least 2022. Its operations combine espionage with infrastructure abuse, extracting sensitive network intelligence while converting compromised systems into covert relay nodes that support wider state-aligned activity.

Attack Regions



UAT-7290

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Attack Details

#1

Since at least 2022, a China-linked advanced persistent threat known as UAT-7290 has conducted a sustained cyber-espionage campaign against high-value telecommunications infrastructure. The group pursues two tightly integrated goals: penetrating networks to extract sensitive intelligence and converting compromised systems into covert relay infrastructure that supports wider state-aligned cyber activity.

#2

The operation reflects high operational discipline. The actor performs extensive reconnaissance before intrusion, exploits publicly disclosed vulnerabilities in edge networking devices, and deploys a custom malware framework built primarily for Linux environments. Its recent expansion into Southeastern Europe marks a clear increase in geographic reach and strategic intent.

#3

UAT-7290 follows a structured attack sequence. It begins with detailed technical mapping of targeted telecom environments, then exploits recently disclosed vulnerabilities in edge devices, often using publicly available proof-of-concept code. These efforts are reinforced with targeted SSH brute-force attacks against exposed systems.

#4

Once access is achieved, the group installs a specialized Linux-based malware stack designed for persistence on edge devices. The infection chain starts with RushDrop, a dropper that performs anti-analysis checks before deploying the DriveSwitch loader and the SilentRaid backdoor. SilentRaid establishes persistent command-and-control access, enabling remote shell execution, port forwarding, file manipulation, and credential theft.

#5

After stabilization, compromised systems are repurposed as Operational Relay Boxes through the Bulbature implant. These relay nodes anonymize and route traffic for subsequent Chinese cyber operations, masking origin and attribution. This dual-use approach maximizes the intelligence and operational value of each compromised asset while strengthening the broader offensive infrastructure.

Recommendations



Strengthen Edge Device Security: Patch internet-facing networking appliances immediately after vulnerability disclosure. Disable unnecessary services and restrict management interfaces to trusted networks only.



Improve Network Visibility and Monitoring: Deploy continuous monitoring for abnormal outbound traffic, port forwarding behavior, and persistent command-and-control patterns, especially on edge and Linux-based systems.



Restrict Lateral Movement and Persistence: Apply least-privilege principles on network devices. Regularly audit startup scripts, cron jobs, and firmware integrity to detect implanted persistence mechanisms.



Potential MITRE ATT&CK TTPs

<u>TA0001</u> Initial Access	<u>TA0002</u> Execution	<u>TA0003</u> Persistence	<u>TA0005</u> Defense Evasion
<u>TA0006</u> Credential Access	<u>TA0007</u> Discovery	<u>TA0009</u> Collection	<u>TA0011</u> Command and Control
<u>TA0010</u> Exfiltration	<u>TA0043</u> Reconnaissance	<u>TA0042</u> Resource Development	<u>T1595</u> Active Scanning
<u>T1587</u> Develop Capabilities	<u>T1588</u> Obtain Capabilities	<u>T1190</u> Exploit Public-Facing Application	<u>T1110</u> Brute Force
<u>T1059</u> Command and Scripting Interpreter	<u>T1543</u> Create or Modify System Process	<u>T1027</u> Obfuscated Files or Information	<u>T1497</u> Virtualization/Sandbox Evasion

<u>T1140</u> Deobfuscate/Decode Files or Information	<u>T1564</u> Hide Artifacts	<u>T1027.002</u> Software Packing	<u>T1552</u> Unsecured Credentials
<u>T1082</u> System Information Discovery	<u>T1016</u> System Network Configuration Discovery	<u>T1083</u> File and Directory Discovery	<u>T1005</u> Data from Local System
<u>T1071</u> Application Layer Protocol	<u>T1132</u> Data Encoding	<u>T1573</u> Encrypted Channel	<u>T1090</u> Proxy
<u>T1572</u> Protocol Tunneling	<u>T1041</u> Exfiltration Over C2 Channel	<u>T1595.002</u> Vulnerability Scanning	<u>T1587.001</u> Malware
<u>T1588.005</u> Exploits	<u>T1110.001</u> Password Guessing	<u>T1059.004</u> Unix Shell	<u>T1497.001</u> System Checks
<u>T1564.001</u> Hidden Files and Directories	<u>T1552.001</u> Credentials In Files	<u>T1071.001</u> Web Protocols	<u>T1573.002</u> Asymmetric Cryptography
<u>T1090.002</u> External Proxy	<u>T1588.006</u> Vulnerabilities		

✂ Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

TYPE	VALUE
SHA256	723c1e59accbb781856a8407f1e64f36038e324d3f0bdb606d35c359ade08200, 59568d0e2da98bad46f0e3165bcf8adadbf724d617ccebcfdaeafbb097b81596, 961ac6942c41c959be471bd7eea6e708f3222a8a607b51d59063d5c58c54a38d

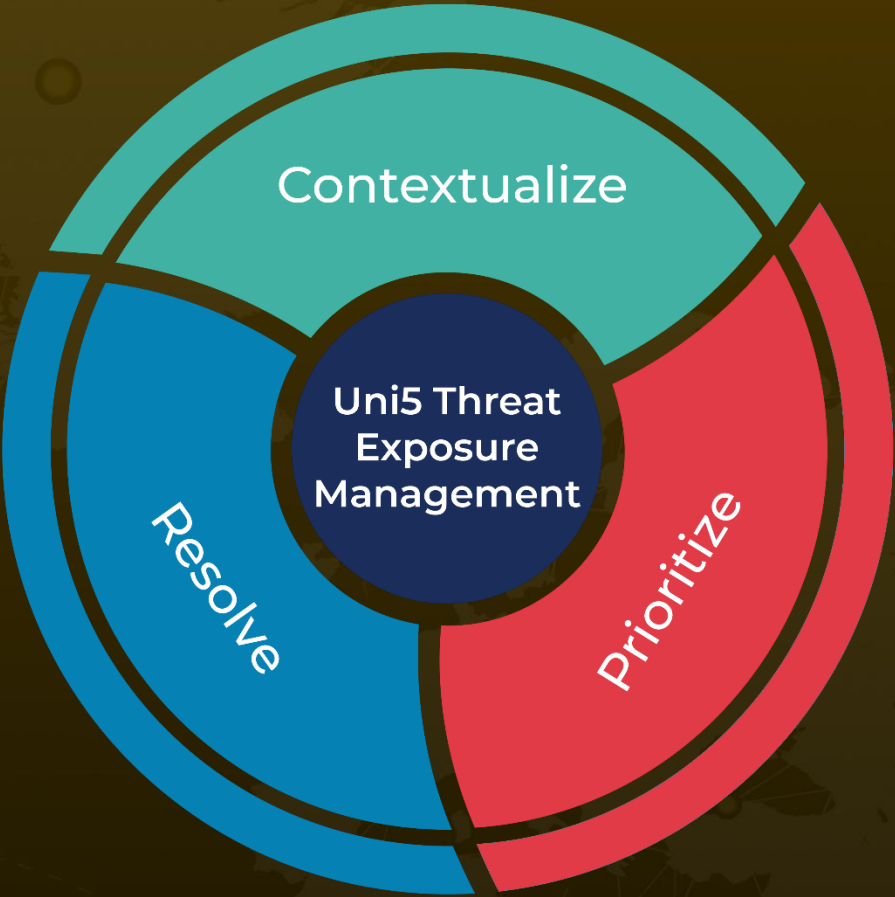
✂ References

<https://blog.talosintelligence.com/uat-7290/>

What Next?

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